MGT 605: Organizational Leadership and Management

FINAL EXAM

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1. **Of the several management and leadership models and frameworks we have examined and analyzed in this course, identify two (2) models that are most compelling to you AND respond to these questions:**
    a. **What 2 models did you select?**
    b. **Why is each of these models compelling to you?**
    c. **How might you adopt or adapt these 2 models to your current or future company or organization, and to your post-MBA career path?**

Throughout the course of the last 28 days we, as a class, have been exposed to numerous compelling and groundbreaking management models and frameworks. From day one where we focused our attention on Peter Drucker and his renowned "five most important questions you will ask in business," to the final week where we explored Blue Ocean Concept's unique approach of eliminating, reducing, raising, and creating business opportunities, the array of ideas and methodologies has been astounding. Of all the frameworks explored, the two which most completely demanded my attention were The Competing Values Framework and Cognitive Bias Theory.

The competing values framework is exquisitely dynamic because it explores the idea that all four primary frameworks (collaborative, creative, controlling, and competitive) are needed in business. Extraordinary freedom is attained when the idea that only one right way of doing business is abandoned and replaced with the idea that all frames have value. Leadership is challenged to constantly seek a better way, and given the tools find and implement the change.

Cognitive bias theory is remarkable in its ability to explore why decisions are made in business; specifically focusing on three ingrained negative responses to stress and conflict: sunk

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cost trap, overconfidence, and recency effect. Being able to identify when each of these responses is taking place is crucial for leadership to mitigate devastating results. The example given of the Mt. Everest climbing disaster of 1996 is an impactful case study displaying the overwhelming costs when the three afore mentioned responses are ignored.

Serving my country for the past 20 years has afforded me the amazing opportunity to both serve and lead under conditions that many people will never experience, and few can comprehend. While the work and cause are admirable, intellectual gaps are created when questions are asked about why orders or directions have been given and the accepted response is "because we were told to do it." Cognitive bias theory affords me the opening to reflect on decisions my military leaders made, as well as on decisions I made, and determine if there could have been a better way. The competing values framework empowers me to find new methods and strategies for making decisions and the instruments to implement them. Moving forward into my planned field of corporate training, the intellectual gap is narrowed, and I'm better equipped to assess needs as they arise.

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How has our discussion and the course-long "thread" of the concept of paradoxical thinking impacted or influenced your thinking about making decisions and searching for solutions in your current or future company or organization?

The concept of paradoxical thinking creates an environment, both internally and externally, where asking the question "why?" is moved from taboo to applauded. Too many times great leaders are stifled from reaching their true potential because company norms are treated as absolute truths or accepted standard are not allowed to be questioned. Companies continue these "tried and true" methods directly into nonexistence. Paradoxical thinking breaks away from this approach and creates a space for intellectual freedom to live.

Paradoxical thinking can be viewed as opportunity. An opportunity for me to question how I approach leadership, management, and career decisions. An opportunity to find new approaches to making decisions. Freedom is attained because the concepts of "one right way" or "the only option" are eliminated. Instead many ideas can live and best fitting solutions can be implemented in real time. If different solutions work better for the same problem at different times, paradoxical thinking allows both to exist.

Freedom to not have to approach situations with the same mindset every time is empowering. I am still in a period of career transition in my life, with a move from military defense to corporate engagement looming in the near future. Paradoxical thinking allows me to lean on my past experiences, but still keep an open mind and a willingness to explore new methods of leadership.

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